WP-4B-05: Insulin and the management of hypoglycaemia

Example General Hospital, Ward 4B. Version 3 (fictional). Owner: Ward 4B nurse in charge (fictional role).

FICTIONAL TRAINING DOCUMENT. Not clinical guidance. Example General Hospital is fictional.

Scope

Adult inpatients on Ward 4B receiving insulin, or with a blood glucose below 4.0 mmol/L.

Definition

Hypoglycaemia is a blood glucose below 4.0 mmol/L, with or without symptoms.

Patient conscious and able to swallow

- Give 15 to 20 g of fast-acting carbohydrate, for example 150 to 200 mL of fruit juice.
- Recheck blood glucose after 10 to 15 minutes. Repeat the treatment up to three times if it is still below 4.0 mmol/L.
- Once above 4.0 mmol/L, give a longer-acting carbohydrate such as a sandwich or the next meal.

Patient unconscious or unable to swallow

Call the emergency team. Give intravenous glucose or intramuscular glucagon as prescribed. Do not give anything by mouth.

Insulin doses

Do not omit insulin for a patient with type 1 diabetes, even if they are not eating. Contact the diabetes team for advice. Insulin is a time-critical medicine (see WP-4B-06).

Ward 4B local rule

Record every glucose result and every treatment given in MedTrack, with the time.